Leaving for US for PhD

back stopping every fifty metres at a shop to warm himself up. While that day changed Satya's perception of the winter in America, it was also the day he was properly introduced to someone who would become a lifelong friend, mentor, and business partner.

Journey with Intel and return to India

Soon after finishing his PhD, Satya joined one of the giants in the semiconductor industry—Intel Corporation—while they were just starting out their supercomputing division. He recalls, "Before they became famous for their iCore and Pentium processors, Intel was looking to make supercomputers using their own processors. I joined in to help develop breakthrough technology."

Those two years working on building supercomputers were the most satisfying and important part of his career. Satya says, "I learnt a lot while at Intel—the values of creating an organisational structure, values of disciplined engineering, attention to detail, delegation which nobody teaches you. You learn by being part of the process."

"We were working on groundbreaking technology. We developed the fastest computer at that time and broke the teraflop barrier in a single machine. Nobody had been able to do that before. We were 2.5x faster than the previous fastest computer," he continues.

After working on supercomputers for two years, Satya moved on to become part of the Strategic Cad Labs at Intel, where he spent another four years. Intel was also where Satya worked very closely with the man he met while attending the Chicago conference—Naveed Sherwani.

Dr Satya Gupta with Dr A.P.J. Kalam

A fine morning in 1999, Naveed came to Satya with a proposal of starting a new initiative at Intel to build ASICs. A precursor to Intel's Foundry Services initiative today, the goal of this new initiative would be to create chips for any customer. And thus, under the leadership of Naveed and Satya, Intel Microelectronics Systems (IME) was formed. But six months into the implementation of the initiative, they realised they need to build capabilities in India to help them grow this venture.

This was a period when Satya's career in the USA was flourishing by leaps and bounds as a semiconductor leader. From being a young student at BITS Pilani, who struggled with English, he now held the esteemed position of Director, Intel at the headquarters—a position many professionals aspire to reach. But fancy titles did not tempt him as much as the desire to contribute to building his country did.

"I thought it was the right time and I always wanted to do things for India in India," he recalls.

And within a week's time, Satya packed his bags and left everything behind to come back to India to build Intel Microelectronics Systems.

Back in India, Intel's operations had very limited chip design activity. As such, Satya and his team were only provided with a small office on Infantry Road in Bangalore to work. Even then, Satya made the most of the situation, focusing on building the expertise of the team.

Satya says, "This team has produced some of the biggest names in the industry who have gone on to become VPs and MDs of global chip companies." Heading the production of something so important allowed Satya to be involved in the intricacies of end-to-end